Grant Benjamin

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Citizenship: Canadian

Research Interests: Empirical Microeconomics, Urban Economics, Public Economics, Real Estate Economics

Education

Ph.D. in Economics, University of Toronto — 2027 (Expected)
Committee: Nathaniel Baum-Snow (supervisor), Stephan Heblich, Jonathan Hall, Robert Clark
M.A. in Economics, University of British Columbia — 2019
B.A. in Politics, Philosophy, and Economics, Mount Allison University — 2018

Working Papers

It Only Takes OneBite: Attention Shocks in Local Markets
Job Market Paper. Available upon request.

Braking Habits: The Impact of Leading Pedestrian Intervals
Revise and Resubmit at Journal of Public Economics

Works-In-Progress

The Wheels on the Bus Go First with Devin Bissky-Dziadyk

Urban Reserves with Stephan Heblich

Housing Affordability Under Tax Reforms

Other Projects

Reproducibility and Robustness of Economics and Political Science Research with Abel Brodeur et al. (see full list of authors on pages 2-3)
Nature. April 1, 2026.

Preventing and Countering Violent Extremism: Best Practices and Standardizations with Matthew John Cross
Handbook of Security Science. Springer International Publishing. September 28, 2022.

Negative COVID-19 vaccine information on Twitter: content analysis with Niko Yiannakoulias, J Connor Darlington, and Catherine E Slavik
JMIR infodemiology. JMIR Publications. August 29, 2022.

Mortality, temperature, and public health provision: A comment on Cohen and Dechezlepretre (2022) with Benjamin Couillard, and Jonathan Hall
I4R Discussion Paper Series, 2022.

Awards and Grants

Ontario Graduate Scholarship (Doctoral) ($10,000)	2026
SSHRC Canada Graduate Scholarship (Doctoral) ($35,000 × 1, $40,000 × 2)	2023 - 2026
School Of Cities Graduate Student Fellowship ($3,500)	2024
Samuel Hollander Graduate Award ($2,000)	2024
University of Toronto Doctoral Fellowship ($7,000 × 5)	2021 - present
University of Toronto Graduate Program Award ($1,000 × 3)	2021 - present
Faculty Of Arts And Science Fellowship ($1,000 × 3)	2021 - 2023
SSHRC Canada Graduate Scholarship (Masters) ($17,500)	2018
University of British Columbia Masters Fellowship ($8,000)	2018
Mount Allison University Don Norton Award	2018
Mount Allison University Leadership Award	2018
Harold Simpson Award in Economics	2018

Professional Experience

Teaching Assistant — 2021 - present

- ECO 101: Principles of Microeconomics (2022)
- ECO 202: Macroeconomic Theory and Policy (2021)
- ECO 208: Macroeconomic Theory (2025)
- ECO 333: Urban Economics (2023 - 2026)
- ECO 372: Data Analysis and Applied Econometrics in Practice (2021 - 2023, 2026)
- ECO 502: Lead Stata Teaching Assistant (2022)
- ECO 504: Lead Writing Integrated Teaching Assistant (2022 - 2025)

Research Assistant — 2022 - present

- Aloysius Siow (2022 - 2024)
- Jonathan Hall (2022 - present)
- Nathanial Baum-Snow (2023 - present)

Conference Presentations

Canadian Economics Association Meetings (Vancouver)	2026
North American Meeting of the Urban Economics Association (Montreal)	2025
University of Toronto Ph.D. Urban Conference (Toronto)	2025
School of Cities Fellowship Conference (Toronto)	2024

Refereeing Experience

Journal of Urban Economics (x3)

Academic Service

Graduate Student Union Social Planner	2025 - 2026
Co-Organizer of the Graduate Student Workshop	2024 - present
Co-Organizer of the Empirical Microeconomics Seminar Series	2024
Ph.D. Academic Mentor	2023 - present
North American Meeting of the Urban Economics Association Assistant	2023
Graduate Student Union Representative	2021 - 2022

Languages

English (native), French (intermediate)
Programming: Python, Stata, R, GIS (using Python and R), LaTeX, Tableau, SQL

References

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It Only Takes OneBite: Attention Shocks in Local Markets

In an era of information abundance, scarce attention constrains consumer choice. Exploiting a unique quasi-experimental setting, I investigate how viral attention from a *OneBite* pizza review on YouTube affects firm performance. Using a staggered event study framework, I find that total customers at the reviewed pizzeria increase in the first two months following the review. The increase, however, critically depends on the review score. While scores < 7.0 and scores in the range $[7.0, 8.0)$ generate no significant improvements, scores ≥ 8.0 increase customers by over 46% in the first two months following the review. The increase in customer traffic generates positive spatial spillovers onto nearby retail establishments, evidence of consumer-based agglomeration. Despite the initial increase, all metrics revert to pretreatment levels within three months, as viral attention fades. Using a rational inattention model, I decompose the demand response into two channels: an attention channel that draws in consumers previously unaware of the pizzeria, and an information channel that updates a consumer's beliefs about pizzeria quality. A two-step GMM structural estimation shows that attention and information contribute in comparable magnitude for high-score reviews, whereas the negative information channel from a low-score review offsets the positive attention shock.

Braking Habits: The Impact of Leading Pedestrian Intervals

After introducing traffic safety measures, motorists often adopt riskier driving habits that offset the intended safety improvement. Exploiting a quasi-natural experiment in Toronto, I investigate how leading pedestrian intervals, advance walk signals that provide pedestrians a head start when crossing an intersection before motorists, impact pedestrian safety and influence motorist behaviour. I estimate that leading pedestrian intervals decrease the probability of a pedestrian collision at an intersection by 39%, with a 56% decrease in the likelihood of a pedestrian fatality or major injury. Rather than a behavioural offset, I determine that leading pedestrian intervals elicit a positive behavioural response from motorists to improve traffic safety.